be among the highest-grossing Hindi films ever made, with the collection in the first two weeks alone surpassing Rs 200 crore. Says Sushil Pandit, who runs Roots in Kashmir, an activist organisation that fights for the rights of and justice for Kashmiri Pandits: "The movie shows the raw truth of what we went through in Kashmir, what led to our expulsion and how much blood and woe was seen, which had so far been swept under the carpet, never talked about in such graphic detail. The film strips away all the usual window-dressing and embroidery and shows the trauma in stark nakedness and truthfulness."

Not all Pandits, though, give it this ringing endorsement. In Srinagar, Sanjiv Tickoo, president of the Kashmiri Pandit Sangharsh Samiti (KPSS), an organisation that has led campaigns against the political and administrative isolation of the community, says, "I do not see any ray of hope for reconciliation because the way the movie has been made it has created further polarisation and is spreading hate. All Kashmiri Muslims have been labelled as terrorists and the government will have to do some damage control. The movie does show some real episodes, but the picturisation is sensationalist and there are many factual inaccuracies." Citing the episode in the film where a terrorist lines up Hindus and shoots them down, he says the event took place only in 2003. Nor were any Pandits killed while they were on their way to Jammu after being driven out from the Valley, as the scene in the film depicts.

Former chief minister Farooq Abdullah, though he is not named in the film, is livid with the way he and other Kashmiri Muslims have been portrayed. In an interview to INDIA TODAY (see '*Form a Truth Commission...*'), he said, "It is nothing but a propaganda film. It has raked up the 1990 tragedy that affected every soul in the state, not just our Hindu brethren who had to leave but also the Muslim majority. It was a sad situation because of some elements interested in ethnic cleansing and who needed to be exposed. But is it necessary to create such hype in the country against Muslims? Leave aside the Muslims in Jammu and Kashmir, Muslims in the rest of India too are facing the brunt of something they had nothing to do with. This propaganda will lead to the destruction of the nation itself by creating hatred between 80 per cent of the population and the remaining 20 per cent." Abdullah wants the Indian government to set up a Truth Commission to investigate not only the killings of Hindus in the Valley, but also of Muslims and Sikhs in the past three decades. "If Farooq Abdullah is responsible," he goes on to say, "he is ready to be hanged anywhere in the nation. I am ready to stand trial but don't blame people who are not responsible."

Despite its famed spirit of Kashmiriyat, resentment had been brewing against the Pandits' **political, social and economic dominance**

While Agnihotri's film has evoked diverse reactions, what it has done is sharp-focused on one of the darkest chapters of recent Indian history. The ethnic cleansing—Tickoo calls it cultural genocide—is deserving of national condemnation, the perpetrators of these heinous crimes need to be brought to justice and victims need to be rehabilitated. That many Pandit grievances remain unaddressed despite the passage of three decades is a national shame too. While the film may be selective in its portrayal of history and prone to inaccuracies and exaggerations, it does raise several troubling questions: What is the truth about the exodus of Kashmiri Pandits from the Valley? Who was responsible for letting things reach such a tragic pass? How are the Pandits faring now? What can bring closure to this blot on our national conscience? Can the Pandits ever return to the Valley and reclaim their place in their homeland? There are no easy answers to these questions, but it may be a useful exercise to begin at the beginning.

WHAT IS THE TRUTH BEHIND THE EXODUS?

The Kashmiri Pandits may have accounted for just 4 per cent of J&K's population, but their influence over the affairs of the state far exceeded their numbers. Part of the ruling elite during the harsh Dogra rule, the erudite and affluent among them got entrenched in the top echelons of power both at the Centre and in the state government post-1947. Before the 1950 and 1976 land reform acts, Pandits owned around 30 per cent of the farmland in the state, in addition to cornering a major share of the commerce. The famed spirit of Kashmiriyat or the centuries-old tradition of religious syncretism and communal harmony aside, resentment had been brewing over their dominance in social, economic and political affairs in the Muslim-majority state. It found fertile ground in a frontier state prone to continuous turbulence and turmoil. That resentment would reach its peak in the late 1980s.

Before the 1990 exodus of Kashmiri Pandits, India had already fought two major wars with Pakistan in 1947 and 1965 over the accession of J&K to the Indian Union and an indirect one in the 1971 Bangladesh War. Then there was the contentious Article 370 that guaranteed J&K special status under the Indian Constitution and gave it greater autonomy than most other states, till it was revoked by the Modi government in August 2019. The political leadership of the state was another vexed issue. Following Independence, it was vested briefly with the charismatic Sheikh Abdullah, but after